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Fundamentals of Entrepreneurial Management I

Introduction

“Fundamentals of Entrepreneurial Management I” is an integrative capstone course in entrepreneurship. It is based on the insight that in today’s business environment entrepreneurial management skills are key for general managers and entrepreneurs alike. The course introduces cutting-edge material – tools, frameworks, perspectives – that allow you to acquire the basics of entrepreneurial management. The course encourages you to adopt a holistic perspective on building new businesses, identifying key assumptions, and developing an entrepreneurial mindset.

Objectives

The course pursues two main objectives. First, it aims at enabling you to turn an idea into a revenue-generating business. The course offers valuable academic and practical knowledge and management tools to foster disciplined innovation and experimentation mindset, useful for your future careers as entrepreneurial leaders. Second, the course addresses your potential concerns and doubts about whether you “have what it takes” to be an entrepreneur. We do this by opening up the “black box” of entrepreneurship and by making the process clear and understandable.

Content

The first sessions of the course explore the entrepreneur’s behavior, the nature of business opportunities, and the process of building a business. An entrepreneur’s fundamental challenge in implementing a new business is to identify, acquire, and manage necessary resources to “create something from nothing.” In the second part of the course, we discuss this key challenge with regard to financing the business and assembling the team. The course leverages a series of frameworks and tools to help in the design of the business model, testing key assumptions, planning, and scaling the business, as well as enables hands-on learning through a variety of in-class exercises.

Evaluation

Grading type	Weight	Evaluation elements
Participation, engagement, and contribution to class learning	50%	The most important part of your learning in this course will take place in the classroom. Participation and contribution to class learning will be determined by preparation for class, active participation in class discussions, and your ability to demonstrate that you have prepared the materials assigned to a particular class, both in terms of quality and quantity (with greater weight on the quality and depth of your answers).
Written exam	40%	The exam will be an open-book group exam to be taken on campus. Instructions will be provided.
Class polling	10%	Answer two pre-class polls (5% each) on Virtual Campus by 9 pm the day before class: a preparation survey before our first and ninth sessions.

Course Outline

Topic	Case / Activity
1. Introduction to Entrepreneurship	Alhoia Capital
2. From Idea to Business Model	Blue River
3. Getting Started I	Simulation
4. Getting Started II	Interactive session
5. Testing the Business Model	Rent the Runway
6. Financing the Venture I	Negotiation exercise
7. Financing the Venture II	Interactive session
8. Assembling a Winning Team	CarbonZen
9. Taking the Leap	Aparkalo
10. Scaling the Business	Flywire
Final Exam	

Detailed Course Outline

Session 1 – Introduction to Entrepreneurship

Pre-class poll: *Please complete the pre-class poll; link available on Virtual Campus no later than 9 pm the day before the class*

Case: Alhoia Capital

Discussion Questions:

1. Which of these opportunities would you choose? Why?
2. What are the criteria that should be used to evaluate business opportunities? Why?
3. Should they be the same criteria for the entrepreneur and for the investor?

Post-class reading:

Johnson. R. Assessing a new business opportunity. EN-17-E.

Optional podcast

3D printing houses at ICON: Jason Ballard
<https://open.spotify.com/episode/3KK70QINQIzaKbDCKGaBxi>

Session 2 – From Idea to Business Model

Case: Blue River Technology (A)

Discussion Questions:

1. Do you recommend a service model or an equipment model for lettuce thinning opportunity?
2. Are you concerned about the differences that have emerged between Jorge and Khosla Ventures over the strategy of Blue River Technology? Why or why not?

Reading: Amit, R., Zott, C. 2021. Business model innovation strategy. Chapter 1 (read pp. 3-18).

Optional podcast

AMP Robotics: Developing machine vision for recycling
<https://open.spotify.com/episode/7iQPZO09ReF8d37sH4rEir>

Sessions 3-4 – Getting Started I and II

Case: None, class is based on a simulation. Please bring a laptop to class.

Reading: Blank S. 2013. Why the lean start-up changes everything, Harvard Business Review.

Session 5 – Testing the Business Model

Case: Rent the Runway (HBS)

Discussion questions:

1. How do you evaluate the different steps undertaken by Rent the Runway cofounders to launch their business?
2. What key business model hypotheses did Jenn and Jenny make? How did they validate these hypotheses?

3. Did the founders make any mistakes in hypothesis testing?
4. What should Jenny and Jenn do about the question posed at the end of the case – either scaling up faster by pursuing new opportunities (e.g., accessories) or focusing on operational improvements?

Post-class

Reading:

Eisenmann, T., Ries, E., Dillard, S. (2013). Hypothesis-driven entrepreneurship: The Lean startup. 9-812-095 (skim)

Optional podcast

Calendly: Tope Awotona
<https://open.spotify.com/episode/3BSfP7WpmODt3yLxD2NbBS>

Sessions 6 - 7 – Financing the Venture I and II

Case: None, in-class negotiation exercise.

Reading: Kerr, W., Nanda, R., McQuade, J. Financing entrepreneurial ventures, pages 1-18 and 30-35.

Optional video:

<https://www.ycombinator.com/library/DX-understanding-investor-terms- incentives>

Further optional readings:

Graham, P. How to raise money (<http://paulgraham.com/fr.html>)

Balachandra, L. How venture capitalists really assess a pitch. Harvard Business Review, 2017.

Malhotra D. How to negotiate with VCs. Harvard Business Review, 2013.

Session 8 – Assembling a Winning Team

Case: Carbon Zen

Discussion Questions:

1. What is your assessment of the job that Lara has done getting started and assembling the team?
2. How do you assess the equity distribution between the founding members? Is it fair? Why or why not? What other factors would you consider? (You may consider online sources to guide your answer, e.g. search for “founder equity calculator”)
3. Which investor would you go for? Why? What possible disadvantages could Carbon Zen face with this deal?

Optional Reading: Optional Podcast

Wasserman, N. The founder’s dilemma. Harvard Business Review, 2008.

Saysh: Allison & Wes Felix
<https://open.spotify.com/episode/0QSpUvMpYujsz3Lo3V65ix>

Session 9 – Taking the Leap

Pre-class poll: *Please complete the pre-class poll; link available on Virtual Campus no later than 9 pm the day before the class*

Case: Aparkalo (A)

Discussion Questions:

1. What are the strengths and weaknesses of the Aparkalo business plan?

2. Evaluate Ivan and Luis's efforts to date. Have they done their homework? What else could they do?
3. If Ivan and Luis asked you for money, would you invest in their venture?

Reading: Sahlman W. A. How to write a great business plan. Harvard Business Review, 1997
 Updating a classic: writing a great business plan (skim)
<https://hbswk.hbs.edu/item/updating-a-classic-writing-a-great-business-plan>

Session 10 – Scaling the Business

Case: Flywire

Discussion Questions:

1. Should Massaro take the CEO position? Why? Why not?
2. How big of an opportunity is it? What do you consider the main strengths, weaknesses, opportunities, and threats for Flywire?
3. When it comes to future growth, should the company race for scale? Or should they slow down growth and investment? In your answer, you can use financials posted on Virtual Campus (note that the third column covers January – May 2013)

Reading: Eisenmann, T. Wagonfeld A. B. Scaling a startup: people and organizational issues. 9-812-100 (skim).
 Lessons from Coinbase's Wild Ascent: Four Rules for Scaling
<https://review.firstround.com/lessons-from-coinbases-wild-ascent-four-rules-for-scaling/>

Optional podcast Warby Parker: Neil Blumenthal and Dave Gilboa
<https://open.spotify.com/episode/7kQY4gs8tF01NIWqut2l9x>

Bibliography

Selected media: podcasts, videos, blogs

Raz, G. How I Built This <https://wonderly.app.link/Y8DuyyMu8nb>

Altman, S. How to Start a Startup (YCombinator), <https://startupclass.samaltman.com/>

Pitch Deck examples from celebrity startups, <https://piktochart.com/blog/startup-pitch-decks-what-you-can-learn>

Selected readings: articles and book chapters (optional)

Identifying venture opportunities

- Hornblower J. and Rohan D. Identifying venture opportunities. Stanford, 11/18/2008, (E- 323)
- Kuemmerle W. A test for the fainthearted. Harvard Business Review, 2002, pp. 122-127 (R0205J)
- Mollick E., The unicorn's shadow, Chapter 2: Ideas – Searching for a light bulb. 2020.

Business models, business plans, and Lean Startup

- Bocken, N., Snihur, Y. Lean Startup and the business model: Experimenting for novelty and impact. Long Range Planning, 53(4), 2020.

- Green, F.J. and Hopp C. Writing a business plan makes your startup more likely to succeed. Harvard Business Review, 2017.
- Zott, C., Amit, R. Business models and Lean startup. Journal of Management, 50(8), 2024.

Testing and validating opportunities

- Blank, S., and Eckhardt, J. T. The lean startup as an actionable theory of entrepreneurship. Journal of Management, 50(8), 2024.
- McGrath, R. G. Who Learns Fastest, Wins: Lean Startup and Discovery Driven Growth. Journal of Management, 50(8), 2024.

Corporate entrepreneurship

- Ashford S. J., Detert J., Get the boss to buy in. Harvard Business Review, 2015
- Kapoor R., Klueter T., Organizing for new technologies. Sloan Management Review Magazine, 2017
- Open innovation: building, scaling and consolidating your firm's corporate venturing unit. IESE, 2018
- Open innovation: corporate venturing success cases tackling the most common challenges. Prats, M.J.; Siota, J; et al. IESE, 2019.

Selected readings: books (optional)

Amit, R., Zott, C. Business model innovation strategy: Transformational concepts and tools for entrepreneurial leaders. John Wiley & Sons, 2021.

Blank, S. G. The four steps to the epiphany. Successful strategies for products that win. Cafepress, 2010.

Eisenmann T., The fail-safe startup. Penguin Books, 2021.

Fitzpatrick, R. The mom test: how to talk to customers & learn if your business is a good idea when everyone is lying to you, 2019.

Hoffman, R., Yeh, C. Blitzscaling. Penguin Random House, 2018.

Kupor, S. Secrets of Sand Hill road: venture capital and how to get it. Penguin Random House, 2019.

MacMillan, I.C. The entrepreneurial mindset. Harvard Business School Press, 2000.

McGrath, R. Seeing around corners: how to spot inflection points in business before they happen. Houghton Mifflin Harcourt, 2019.

Mullins, J. The new business road test: What entrepreneurs and executives should do before writing a business plan. Pearson UK, 2012.

Osterwalder, A. and Pigneur, Y. Business model generation: a handbook for visionaries, game changers, and challengers. John Wiley & Sons, 2010.

Ries, E. The lean start-up. How today's entrepreneurs use continuous innovation to create radically successful. Crown Business, 2011.

Wasserman, N. The founder's dilemmas: anticipating and avoiding the pitfalls that can sink a startup. Princeton University Press, 2012.

Professor's Biography

Associate Professor of Entrepreneurship

HDR (Habilitation to Direct Research), University Toulouse 1, France

PhD, IESE Business School, Spain

Bachelor in International Business, Northeastern University, Boston, USA

Bachelor in European Management, Neoma, France

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Yuliya Snihur is an Associate Professor in the Entrepreneurship Department at IESE. For the past 25 years, Prof. Snihur has worked and lived in France, Belgium, Spain, and the USA. Prof. Snihur teaches courses on entrepreneurship and business model innovation in IESE MBA and Executive Education programs. She advises students and startups, scale-ups, and established firms interested in business model innovation practice and research. She has worked with and mentored entrepreneurs from Africa, Brazil, Europe, and India. She is passionate about helping people and companies innovate and “create something from nothing.”

Prof. Snihur has written a book as well as over 30 refereed academic articles published in top management journals. Her research lies at the intersection of entrepreneurship, innovation, and organization theory. She studies how entrepreneurial leaders design innovative and high-performing business models in both new and established firms when facing technological change, disruptions, and evolving ecosystems.

In addition to being an experienced teacher, researcher, adviser, and mentor, Prof. Snihur has served in a variety of professional leadership positions. For example, she served as the Associate Editor of the Journal of Management Studies, a leading management journal. Additionally, she has supervised several PhD and DBA students that have successfully defended their dissertations in France and in China and acted as external PhD examiner and judge for doctoral research awards.

Additional Information for Reporting and Accreditation purposes

Learning Outcomes

1. Critically evaluate relevant information for better decision-making.
2. Apply negotiation techniques effectively in any environment, ensuring stability and fairness for all parties involved.
3. Integrate economic efficiency, ethical criteria respecting human dignity, and sustainability of the planet into decision-making.
4. Apply necessary tools to prevent and detect fraudulent or unethical behaviors, developing an ethical sense in decision-making.
5. Create rigorous, viable, and sustainable business plans for potential investors.
6. Build innovation processes with an impact on the organization and the market.
7. Develop techniques for effective communication.
8. Analyze the impact of business decisions from the perspective of general management operating in a globally competitive context.
9. Apply entrepreneurial behavior with a creative and open mindset, driving necessary changes with energy and personal responsibility.
10. Develop trust and foster employee identification with the company's mission.
11. Evaluate the impact of the global macroeconomic and microeconomic environments on specific business activities to develop action plans and adapt to uncertain environments.

Sustainable Development Goals (SDG)

- SDG 1 – No Poverty
- SDG 2 – Zero Hunger
- SDG 3 – Good Health and Well-Being
- SDG 4 – Quality Education
- SDG 5 – Gender Equality
- SDG 6 – Clean Water and Sanitation
- SDG 7 – Affordable and Clean Energy
- SDG 8 – Decent Work and Economic Growth
- SDG 9 – Industry Innovation and Infrastructure
- SDG 10 – Reduced Inequalities
- SDG 11 – Sustainable Cities and Communities
- SDG 12 – Responsible Consumption and Production
- SDG 13 – Climate Action
- SDG 14 – Life Below Water
- SDG 15 – Life on Land
- SDG 16 – Peace, Justice and Strong Institutions
- SDG 17 – Partnerships for the Goals